Google launches Gmail SMS
Google has rolled out a new service in Africa that lets Gmail users send and receive emails using the built-in SMS features of their mobile phones

Sparrow acquired by Google
Popular iOS and Mac email client Sparrow was acquired by Google to work on its Gmail team. No new versions of the app are likely to be released

Sony Bravia HX925	963:1	Starts @ ₹1,53,900
Sony Bravia HX750	1129:1	Starts @ ₹83,900
LG LW6500 Cinema 3D	700:1	Starts @ ₹1,04,900
Samsung Series 8 LED Smart TV	983:1	Starts @ ₹1,58,000
Panasonic Smart Viera DT50K	446:1	Starts @ ₹1,33,900

HDTVs: Actual contrast ratios

channels, controlling volume, switching between sources, navigating between the menus and tweaking settings, etc. For this, motion-sensitive remotes are just a pain to use. Depending on how fluent you have become with the entire process, it will take you quite a while to do the same task than it would if you simply picked up the conventional remote and tapped the buttons.

However, motion-sensitive remotes have a huge advantage if you are using the TV for web browsing, social networking or playing games installed on the TV. Angry Birds will work well with a motion remote, something that the conventional remote cannot handle.

Clear Motion – More isn't always better

Please have a look at the table below, before we explain in detail, what we will talk about. All these figures indicate the motive to make fast moving visuals as clear as possible, for your viewing pleasure. And we appreciate this initiative, and support it wholeheartedly. However, there is a fundamental flaw in this feature, and not necessarily its own. Let us illustrate this by multiple scenarios.

Watching blu-ray or full HD uncompressed content: This is where you should probably have the motion flow settings set to max. Not only will any fast motion scenes look a lot smother than otherwise, but with the panel capabilities permitting, there won't be any issues like screen tear etc., largely because the content is the uncompressed type. For the movie buffs, this is probably worth the money they have spent.

Watching compressed HD videos, DVDs or even up-scaled HD content: Somewhere between the two extremes is this scenario, which may work well with motion settings, but equally make the reproduced visuals look bad. Depends on the amount of compression that particular file has been subjected to, and artefacts may be introduced into the image, due to interpolation.

Clear Motion

Watching TV (DTH, Cable etc.): This is where this settings needs to be considerably toned down. Due to the extremely compressed nature of the content broadcast by cable and DTH operators, there will be issues such as screen tear. The clearest example of this is in a cricket match, when the ball running towards the boundary. With motion settings set to their max, you will see three balls running towards the boundary – with the actual one being in the centre, and shadow ones preceding and succeeding it. Turn this setting to Standard / Low / Clear, and the issue goes away. The logic that is brandished around on the shop floor is that with this feature, all visuals will look more fluid and smooth, but as we have explained, that isn't always the case.

Sony Bravia HX925	Motionflow XR800
Sony Bravia HX750	Motionflow XR400
LG LW6500	Motion Clarity 800
Samsung Series 8 LED Smart TV	ClearMotion 800

Fast Visual engines: What is on offer

3D – Which one to get?

Well, 3D isn't as simple as some people think it is. Active 3D seems to be the most popular one around, until LG brought in the Cinema 3D range with the passive 3D technology, technically called the film type patterned retarder.

Passive 3D glasses

Active 3D glasses

The way active 3D works is that the battery-operated glasses rely on signals from the emitter in the TV on when to close the shutter for which eye. This rapid opening and closing of the shutter blocks content from an individual eye at a time. The result isn't pretty – the glasses are heavy and the eyes tend to feel the strain after prolonged viewing. Also, the sweet spot for this type of technology is quite limited – essentially a straight line, with only little leeway either side, which means not more than a couple of people can sit and actually enjoy 3D on a 42 to 46-inch TV. Passive 3D, on the other hand, uses much lighter polarized glasses. The TV doesn't have a transmitter, but polarizes each line of pixels into even and odd. The odd lines will be visible to the left eye, and the even numbered lines to the right eye. Since there is no active shutter, the glasses can be lighter and more comfortable for wearing for longer durations. Also, the viewing angles are wider than with Active 3D, which makes this a better deal for family viewing scenarios. Also there is less strain on the eyes. The only drawback is that with polarized glasses, you only get a maximum resolution of 1920 x 540 pixels, due to the blocking of some lines. So, the next time you go to buy a 3D TV, don't let the guy on the shop floor tell you all 3D TVs are the same.